

Module 04: Cognition — The Family Brain

Learning Objectives

1. Understand that **Cognition** is thinking and making choices.
2. Learn about **Family Rules** (Our shared code).
3. Know that we can solve problems by thinking together.

Introduction: The Control Center

A computer has a CPU. A robot has a processor. A Family has a **Shared Brain**! Wait, what? When we decide what to eat for dinner, we are thinking *together*. When we follow the rule "No Jumping on the Couch," we are sharing a thought. Cognition is how we make sense of our family life.

Key Concepts

1. The Family Model (Our Values)

Every family believes different things.

- Family A: "We love Sports!"
- Family B: "We love Books!"
- Family C: "We help neighbors." This is your **Model** of the world. It guides what you do.

2. Rules (The Code)

Just like a game has rules, a house has rules.

- "Wash hands before eating."
- "Knock before entering." Rules aren't just to be bossy. They help the system run smoothly (Predictions!). If I know you will knock, I feel safe (Good Prediction).

3. Problem Solving

Uh oh! We have a problem.

- The dog ate the cake.
- It is raining on picnic day. What do we do? We use **Cognition**.
- **Stop**: Don't panic.
- **Think**: What are our choices?
- **Act**: Pick the best one.

Activities

Activity 1: The Rule Reboot

Pick one rule in your house. Ask: "Why do we have this rule?"

- Rule: *Brush teeth*.
- Why? *To keep teeth strong*.
- Is it a good rule? *Yes*. Now, invent a SILLY rule.
- "Must hop on one foot to the kitchen." Try it for 10 minutes. Is it efficient? No! (That's why it's not a real rule).

Activity 2: The Family Vote

Have a decision to make? (e.g., Movie night choice). Don't just fight!

1. Everyone proposes an option.
2. Everyone gives a reason ("It's funny", "It's exciting").
3. Vote! This is distributed cognition (Thinking together).

Summary

Cognition is the thinking part of the family system. By understanding our values, following helpful rules, and solving problems together, we make our "Family Brain" super smart!

References

- *Alexander and the Terrible, Horrible, No Good, Very Bad Day* (About handling problems)
- *What Do You Do With a Problem?* by Kobi Yamada